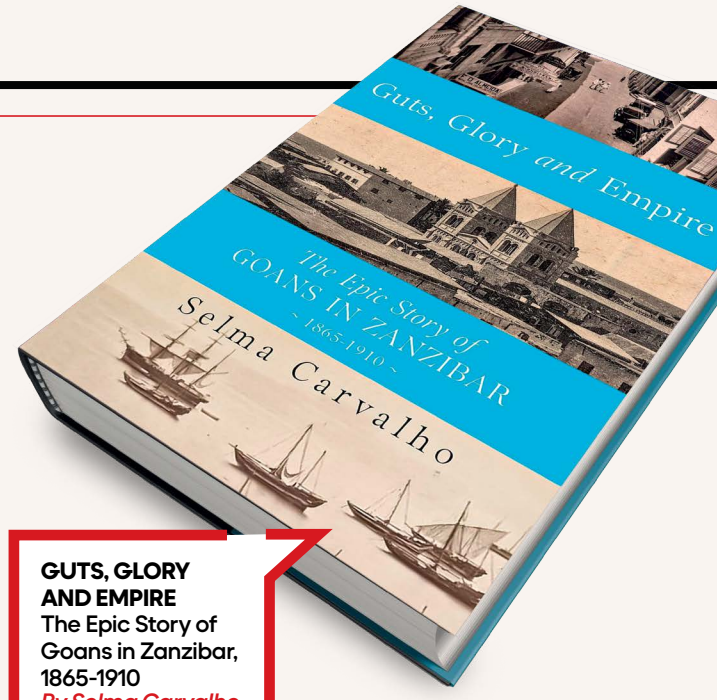
BOOKS ▼

Rare Slice of History

Selma Carvalho examines the Goan presence in Zanzibar during colonial times in this well-researched account



GUTS, GLORY AND EMPIRE
The Epic Story of Goans in Zanzibar, 1865-1910
By Selma Carvalho
SPEAKING TIGER
₹999; 504 pages

Through the colonial period, Indians travelled to parts of Africa as traders, entrepreneurs and indentured workers. But where did Goans, who were part of the subcontinental diaspora but subjects of Portuguese rule, fit in? Historian Selma Carvalho has previously examined the Goan presence in East Africa and in her new work trains her sights on Zanzibar, a small archipelago off the coast of Tanzania. *Guts, Glory and Empire: The Epic Story of Goans in Zanzibar, 1865-1910* narrates with grand sweep and granular detail the story of a unique community in a specific historical moment, drawing on oral histories, archival documents and sheer shoe-leather reporting.

Poised at a strategic point in the Indian Ocean, Zanzibar was an Arab sultanate in the mid-19th century before it passed into British hands. The earliest Goans moved here in 1860, and swelled to over a thousand by 1931. The almost exclusively male migrants were of all stripes: cooks, sailors, doctors, retailers. Many went on to establish roots here and emerged as respected and powerful figures who left an impact on local history and culture.

Unlike other Indian immigrants to Zanzibar, **GOANS WERE SOMEWHERE BETWEEN** Europeans and Asians: both victims and perpetrators of racism

Goans were distinct from the other Indian immigrants to the islands in that they were somewhere between Europeans and Asians in the racial schema—both victims of racism and perpetrators of it. But, in many ways, they were much like their Indian counterparts—colonial subjects navigating tangled bureaucracies and riven by inter-caste politics.

Carvalho dwells on both the big themes—nationhood, racism, imperialist jockeying and heroic enterprise—as well as the minutiae of daily life: weddings, funerals and amusing day-to-day politics. Although *Guts, Glory and Empire* might hold a niche appeal for the lay reader and runs on the longer side, it is a remarkably researched account that surfaces a forgotten slice of the past. ■

—Bhavya Dore

BOOKS ▼

The Queen of Hearts

SAKOON SINGH'S *Fourteen Springs of Separation* brings alive the legend of Maharani Jind Kaur of Punjab, who stood up to the British Empire

SAKOON SINGH'S DEBUT NOVEL, *IN THE LAND OF THE LOVERS* (2020), was a quintessential Punjabi love story. Now she's back with a tale straight from the historical annals of Punjab. Her new book—*Fourteen Springs of Separation*—is a fictional account of the life of Maharani Jind Kaur, the youngest of the wives of Ranjit Singh, the first Maharaja of the Sikh Empire and the mother of Duleep Singh, the last maharaja. Contemporary characters researching Jind Kaur's life are a literary device.

While Singh acknowledges several sources that she tapped into—from Navtej Sarna's *The Exile* (a novel about